Business Required Documents (BRD)
Online Order Return & Refund Process Improvement

Version: 1.0
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Project: Type: Portfolio case study
Date: 07/11/2026

1. Executive Summary

This project focuses on improving the online returns and refund process for a fictional fashion e-commerce company. Customers currently experience delays in receiving refunds and have limited visibility into refund status, resulting in repeated customer-support inquiries. The proposed future-state process introduces improved status visibility, automated status updates, and customer notifications while reducing manual support activities.

2. Business Problem

Customers of the online fashion store experience long return and refund processing times and do not have clear visibility into the status of their refunds. As a result, customers frequently contact Customer Support for updates. Support agents must manually check refund information, increasing workload and creating additional delays. Manual handoffs between Customer Support, Warehouse, Finance, and Payment Providers further contribute to inefficiencies.

3. Business Objectives

BO-01: Improve customer visibility into return and refund status.
BO-02: Reduce customer-support inquiries related to refund status.
BO-03: Reduce manual status-checking activities performed by support agents.
BO-04: Improve communication between return processing stages.
BO-05: Provide automated customer notifications when refund status changes.

4. Scope

The project covers the return process beginning when a customer requests a return and ending when the refund is successfully completed or the return request is closed.

Return request → eligibility check → return authorization → warehouse receipt → item inspection → refund initiation → payment processing → refund-status update → customer notification.

Out of Scope
Product purchasing, order fulfillment, delivery tracking before the return process, inventory forecasting, product recommendations, payment authorization during initial purchase, and fraud-detection modeling are outside the scope of this project.

5. Stakeholders

Stakeholder	**Interest / Responsibility**
Customer	Wants quick returns, clear refund status and timely communication
Customer Support	Handles customer issues and exceptions
Warehouse / Returns	Receives and inspects returned products
Finance	Initiates approved refunds
Payment Provider	Processes refund transactions
E-commerce System	Maintains refund status and sends notifications

6. Business Requirements

BR-01: Customers shall have visibility into the current status of their return and refund.

BR-02: Customers shall receive notifications when significant return or refund status changes occur**.**

BR-03: The business shall reduce dependency on Customer Support for routine refund-status inquiries.

BR-04: Return status shall be updated after warehouse inspection is completed.

BR-05: Refund status shall be updated following confirmation from the payment provider.

BR-06: Customer Support shall retain the ability to assist customers with exception cases.

BR-07: The process shall maintain visibility of rejected or review-required returns.

7. Business Rules

BRULE-01: A return must meet applicable return eligibility criteria before authorization.

BRULE-02: Returned items must be inspected before refund initiation.

BRULE-03: Rejected items shall not automatically proceed to refund processing.

BRULE-04: Refunds shall normally be processed to the customer's original payment method.

BRULE-05: Customers shall be notified when the return or refund status materially changes.

8. Assumptions

This case study uses a fictional online fashion retailer and simulated business conditions. Process volumes, turnaround times and improvement targets are illustrative assumptions created for portfolio analysis and do not represent results from an actual company.

9. Success Metrics

KPI	Current-state assumption	Target
Refund-status support inquiries	Baseline to be simulated	Reduce by 30%
Manual refund-status checks	High manual dependency	Reduce significantly
Refund visibility	Limited	Real-time/updated status available
Customer notifications	Manual/limited	Automated status notifications

10. Risks and Constraints

Risk: Payment provider does not return refund status correctly.
Impact: Customer sees outdated refund information.

Risk: Warehouse inspection is delayed.
Impact: Refund processing cannot begin.

Constraint: Refund processing speed partly depends on external payment providers.

Constraint: Some rejected or unusual cases will continue to require human intervention.

11. References / Supporting Documents

1. AS-IS Returns & Refund Process Map
2. Pain Point & Root Cause Analysis
3. TO-BE Returns & Refund Process Map
4. Stakeholder Analysis
5. User Stories & Acceptance Criteria
6. Wireframes
7. UAT Test Cases